But such actions may also be attributed to the geographical importance of this resource-rich region. As we know, on the Myanmar side, besides being a source for energy itself, the Rakhine Basin along with several parts of the inland have long been regarded as "an emerging oil and gas province".[7] Myanmar's Energy Ministry announced in March 2015 that four blocks in the Rakhine Basin were allotted for exploration by international firms (Chinese and Indian firms were already participating in the Shwe natural gas project from January 2014). With such a level of investment, the region would have to enjoy increased security attention.

The town of Sittwe, the Rakhine State capital, is also in the region. Sittwe has characteristics that make it an important strategic location in the eyes of any government at Naypyitaw. Firstly, it provides the main communication line (through the Bay of Bengal) to Maungdaw, the township nearest to the Bangladesh border where the largest number of Rohingya live. Secondly, besides its importance as a military base, Sittwe has an airport and a seaport (the latter developed by India under a 2007 agreement);[8] the city is also home to the University of Sittwe, a location for potential anti-government dissent.[9]

Also there is the issue of homegrown threats emanating from Myanmar's long-standing problems with the separatist movements in Rakhine State. Starting from the 1990s, these largely indigenous movements went through an apparent lull in insurgency; however, in recent times there have been reports of fresh attempts to ignite insurgency in the state, especially by the Arakan Army (AA) and the Rohingya Solidarity Organisation (RSO).[10] Part of the AA agenda resonates with the pro-independence sections of the Rakhine, and apparently attracts the Buddhist Rakhine, notably, the Rakhine Nationalities Development Party (Keenan 2015); now Arakan National Party (see Than Tun, this volume). Although religion does not appear to be the key issue in this motivation, the ensuing persecution by the armed forces nonetheless affect the Buddhists and Muslims in the state alike (Karim 2000, p. 1).

The actions by the RSO, on the other hand, may be based not only on their need for self-esteem, but also to salvage their Islamic identity, which helps them stand out — perhaps also to acquire a global appeal — as they strive for equal rights alongside Buddhists. Consequently, their struggles to achieve these rights lead to religious repercussions and, since all too often such interests do not converge, put the two into conflict.

With the large Rohingya population in this border area, however,